

WEST BENGAL ORIGIN

Basanti Pulao

Sweet Saffron-Turmeric Festive Rice

The Golden Rice of Bengali Celebrations

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Basanti Pulao

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

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Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

Rice Dressed for a Celebration

Basanti pulao takes its name from the same root as begun basanti — Basant, the Bengali word for spring — and its golden-yellow color, achieved through turmeric and sometimes a touch of saffron, marks it immediately as festive food, most closely tied to Saraswati Puja, weddings, and other joyful Bengali occasions where a plain white rice simply wouldn't fit the mood.

Unlike a savory pulao built around vegetables or meat, basanti pulao leans gently sweet, studded with raisins and cashews and often a hint of sugar, cooked with fragrant ghee and whole spices like cinnamon, cardamom, and cloves. This sweetness is entirely intentional and traditional — the dish is meant to complement rather than compete with the more savory dishes it's served alongside, most classically cholar dal, another dish in this collection.

At a Bengali wedding feast or a Saraswati Puja lunch, basanti pulao's arrival at the table often visually signals that the meal has moved into its more celebratory register — a dish whose golden color and gentle sweetness are, in a very real sense, part of the point, not just the flavor.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

Rice Dressed for a Celebration, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Named for Basant (spring) and its associated golden-yellow color, closely tied to Saraswati Puja, weddings, and festive Bengali occasions. Traditionally paired with cholar dal, another dish in this collection, forming one of Bengal's classic festive food combinations. Intentionally sweet rather than savory, reflecting the dish's role as a celebratory counterpart to richer, spicier dishes on the table. A dish whose golden color carries deliberate symbolic weight at Bengali celebrations, beyond just its flavor.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

10m	30m	6	Easy
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Heavy-bottomed pot with a tight-fitting lid
- Fine mesh strainer, for rinsing and draining the rice
- Wooden spoon or fork, for gentle mixing

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Basanti pulao keeps refrigerated for up to 3 days. Reheat gently with a splash of water, covered, either on the stovetop or in the microwave, to restore moisture without drying out the rice. It freezes reasonably well for up to a month.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the pulao

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Basmati rice	2 cups	400 g	2 katori
Ghee	4 tbsp	60 g	4 chammach
Cashews	3 tbsp	35 g	3 chammach
Raisins	3 tbsp	30 g	3 chammach
Cinnamon stick	1 inch	1 inch	1 inch
Green cardamom	4	4	4
Cloves	4	4	4
Bay leaf	1	1	1
Turmeric powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Saffron strands — optional	a pinch	a pinch	a pinch
Sugar	2 tbsp	25 g	2 tbsp
Water	3½ cups	840 ml	3½ katori
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	to taste

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Basmati rice is strongly preferred for its long grains and fragrance, which suit this festive dish far better than short-grain rice. Saffron is a lovely traditional touch but purely optional, since turmeric alone provides the signature golden color. Ghee is important to the dish's rich, fragrant character; a neutral oil can substitute in a pinch, though it will noticeably reduce the dish's traditional aroma and richness.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Preparing the Rice

01 RINSE AND SOAK THE RICE

Rinse the basmati rice under cold water until the water runs mostly clear, then soak in water for 20–30 minutes. Drain thoroughly before cooking.

02 TOAST THE NUTS AND RAISINS

Heat 2 tablespoons of the ghee in a heavy-bottomed pot and fry the cashews until golden, then add the raisins and fry briefly until plump. Remove both and set aside for garnish.



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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Preparing the Rice, continued

Chef tip. toasting the cashews and raisins separately from the rice, then adding them back at the end, keeps their texture distinct rather than letting them turn soft throughout cooking.

COOKING CHECKPOINT

Properly soaked and drained rice should feel slightly heavier and more pliable than dry rice, which helps it cook evenly without becoming mushy or sticky.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Cooking the Pulao

03 BLOOM THE WHOLE SPICES

In the remaining ghee, add the cinnamon, cardamom, cloves, and bay leaf, letting them sizzle gently for about 30 seconds until fragrant.

04 ADD THE RICE AND TURMERIC

Add the drained rice and turmeric, gently stirring to coat every grain in the ghee and spices, taking care not to break the rice grains. Cook for 2–3 minutes.



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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Cooking the Pulao, continued

05 ADD WATER, SUGAR, AND SAFFRON

Pour in the water, sugar, salt, and saffron if using. Bring to a boil, then reduce heat to the lowest setting, cover tightly, and cook undisturbed for 15–18 minutes.

06 REST AND FLUFF

Turn off the heat and let the pot rest, covered and undisturbed, for 10 minutes — this resting period is essential for evenly cooked, separate grains. Fluff gently with a fork.

Texture indicator. properly cooked basanti pulao should have distinct, separate golden grains, not clumped or mushy — resist stirring during cooking, which breaks the rice.

07 GARNISH AND SERVE

Gently fold in the toasted cashews and raisins just before serving, reserving a few for garnish on top.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Lifting the lid or stirring the rice while it cooks releases essential steam and disrupts even cooking, often resulting in unevenly cooked or gummy rice. Keep the pot covered and undisturbed for the full cooking and resting time.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served alongside cholar dal, the classic festive Bengali pairing for Durga Puja, weddings, and Saraswati Puja.
- A celebratory centerpiece dish that signals a special occasion on the Bengali table.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Restaurant Presentation

- Served in a mound on a plate, garnished with extra cashews and raisins, alongside a rich curry or dal.

Family Style

- A shared festive dish at weddings and puja celebrations, ladled generously alongside other special-occasion dishes.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Texture Right

- Soaking the rice beforehand and keeping the pot undisturbed during cooking are both essential for distinct, fluffy grains.
- The resting period after cooking is just as important as the cooking itself — don't skip it, even though the rice looks done.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- Basanti pulao can be made a few hours ahead and gently reheated, making it practical for entertaining and festival cooking.
- Toast extra cashews and raisins in advance and store separately, adding fresh just before serving for the best texture.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some caterers add a few drops of rose water or kewra water right at the end for an extra-fragrant, celebratory touch — a small but distinctive detail for special occasions.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

310 kcal	5 g	52 g	9 g	1.5 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with oil and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy, Tree nuts. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Basanti Pulao with Saffron	an extra-fragrant version using real saffron alongside turmeric.
Mishti Pulao	a closely related, even sweeter variation popular in some Bengali households.
Basanti Pulao with Vegetables	a modern variation adding peas and carrots for a more substantial dish.

Why is my rice mushy instead of fluffy?

Usually too much water, stirring during cooking, or skipping the soak and rest steps. Follow the measurements and resting time closely for the best texture.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Can I make this without sugar?

The gentle sweetness is a defining characteristic of basanti pulao, but you can reduce the sugar for a milder version if you prefer less sweetness.

What's the difference between this and a regular pulao?

Basanti pulao is intentionally sweeter and more festively colored than a typical savory pulao, which usually skips the sugar and leans more heavily on savory spices and vegetables.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Basanti	Bengali for spring, referring to this dish's golden-yellow color and festive character.
Kewra	a fragrant water distilled from pandanus flowers, sometimes used to finish festive rice dishes.
Pulao	a rice dish cooked with whole spices, often with added nuts or vegetables.
Bhog	food offered to deities during religious observances, sometimes including basanti pulao.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Basanti Pulao

10m	30m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME
6	Easy
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

PULAO

Basmati rice	400 g
Ghee	60 g
Cashews	35 g
Raisins	30 g
Cinnamon stick	1 inch
Green cardamom	4
Cloves	4
Bay leaf	1
Turmeric powder	1.5 g
Saffron strands — optional	a pinch
Sugar	25 g
Water	840 ml
Salt	6 g

METHOD

01 **Rinse and soak the rice.** Rinse the basmati rice under cold water until the water runs mostly clear, then soak in water for 20–30 minutes.

02 **Toast the nuts and raisins.** Heat 2 tablespoons of the ghee in a heavy-bottomed pot and fry the cashews until golden, then add the raisins and fry briefly until plump.

03 **Bloom the whole spices.** In the remaining ghee, add the cinnamon, cardamom, cloves, and bay leaf, letting them sizzle gently for about 30 seconds until fragrant.

04 **Add the rice and turmeric.** Add the drained rice and turmeric, gently stirring to coat every grain in the ghee and spices, taking care not to break the rice grains.

05 **Add water, sugar, and saffron.** Pour in the water, sugar, salt, and saffron if using.

06 **Rest and fluff.** Turn off the heat and let the pot rest, covered and undisturbed, for 10 minutes — this resting period is essential for evenly cooked, separate grains.

07 **Garnish and serve.** Gently fold in the toasted cashews and raisins just before serving, reserving a few for garnish on top.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Basmati rice	400 g	☐ Ghee	60 g
☐ Cashews	35 g	☐ Raisins	30 g
☐ Cinnamon stick	1 inch	☐ Green cardamom	4
☐ Cloves	4	☐ Bay leaf	1
☐ Turmeric powder	1.5 g	☐ Saffron strands — optional	a pinch
☐ Sugar	25 g	☐ Salt	6 g

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